



Mount Everest

Earth's highest mountain, which sits in the Eastern Himalayas

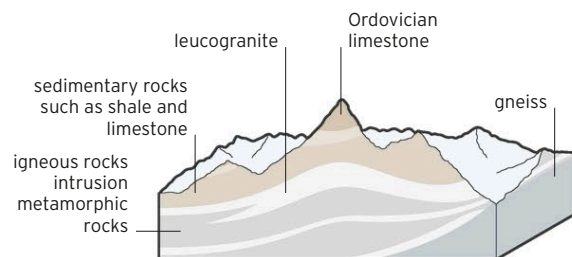
Also known in Nepal as Sagarmatha (meaning “sky head”) and in China as Chomolungma (meaning “Holy Mother”), Mount Everest soars to 29,029 ft (8,848 m) above sea level.

Faces and ridges

Everest is a highly inhospitable place. It is dangerous to climb: fatalities are mainly a result of avalanches, hypothermia, and altitude sickness. The mountain is roughly the shape of a three-sided pyramid, with a southwest face, a north face, and an east face, each very steep. At the intersections of these faces are three ridges—southeast, northeast, and west—leading to the summit. The first confirmed ascent took place in 1953, by Tenzing Norgay and Edmund Hillary, via a route using the southeast ridge. Successful ascents have now been made by at least 18 different routes of varying difficulty using various combinations of ridges and faces.

THE GEOLOGY OF EVEREST

Everest's summit pyramid is composed of limestone that formed on the seafloor some 470 million years ago, during Earth's Ordovician period. Beneath that are other layers of sedimentary rock, and deeper still, metamorphic rocks such as gneiss, with intrusions of igneous rocks.



► AVALANCHE

Avalanches are frequent on Everest. In April 2015, an earthquake triggered a deadly avalanche that swept into the southern base camp and killed 22 people.



Changtse

This peak at 24,747 ft (7,543 m) connects to Everest's summit via the north col.

Rongbuk Glacier

Khumbutse

Lying on the border between Nepal and China, this peak reaches 21,772 ft (6,636 m).

north col

north face

northeast ridge

► EVEREST MASSIF

Viewed here from the west, the Everest massif includes Everest itself and the nearby peaks Lhotse and Nuptse. The ridges between the peaks form a horseshoe shape, enclosing a basin.

► BASE CAMP

There are two main base camps on Everest on different sides of the mountain. These campsites are used by climbers before and after ascents and by hikers. The south camp (seen here), in Nepal, is close to the Khumbu Icefall at 17,598 ft (5,364 m).



There is **66 percent less oxygen** at **Everest's summit** than at sea level